



PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH WITH PAKISTAN PREMIER YOUSAF RAZA GILANI AT SHARM EL-SHEIKH

istan which could earn him a permanent place in history.

Till now, repeated acts of terror, most notably the Mumbai attacks of 26/11, have proved to be a major setback to those ambitions and grounded the fragile peace process. Singh tried to play the peacemaker again at Sharm el-Sheikh in 2009 only to be held back by his own party and the Opposition which pounced on the mention of Balochistan in the joint statement issued there.

Getting **TOUGH** on Peace

After the Pune blast, India's continuation of talks brings a larger message, but it is not without risks

| By Saurabh Shukla |

During Manmohan Singh's first stint as prime minister, the one item high on his diplomatic agenda was to repair ties with Pakistan, an idea articulated in an emotional address in 2007 when he said: "I dream of a day, while retaining our respective national identities, one can have breakfast in Amritsar, lunch in Lahore and dinner in Kabul. That is how my

forefathers lived. That is how I want our grandchildren to live." When he returned as prime minister for a second term in 2009, he pushed the agenda with a group of key advisers. He believes that better relations with Pakistan can allow India to concentrate more effectively on other diplomatic priorities and allow it to play a larger role on the global stage, commensurate with its economic clout. There are also those who believe that he is seeking a breakthrough on Pak-

The dream, however, remained. In 2010, he made a fresh start by rehabilitating his key lieutenant, former foreign secretary Shiv Shankar Menon, as national security adviser. Menon, who had supported his earlier experiments on peace with Pakistan, was told by the prime minister that India needed to make a fresh start. Nudged by international interlocutors like the US, who believed that a dialogue was key to reduce tensions in South Asia, Menon pushed the idea of restarting a formal dialogue. Despite reservations from several senior ministers who argued that this was not the best time, Singh was undeterred and initiated the talks. Once again, the bomb blast in Pune has raised fresh questions on what should India talk to Pakistan, and what should be the focus. After all, more than 174 rounds of talks between the two countries in the last six decades have yielded little. Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao, however, remains hopeful. "This is a standalone meeting of the foreign secretaries.

India must assess Pakistan on the basis of the latter's deeds rather than its